

I longed to pray under the "immortal" Mugumo tree and to commune with the Kikuyu community. I dreamed of playing melodious tunes on the Wandindi, a traditional string instrument, at Kikuyu ceremonies. I needed to be dressed in the Kikuyu cultural regalia, and steal the spotlight at every event I attended. I yearned to be part of the Kikuyu culture, I wanted to learn.

“What is your tribe?” My Social Studies teacher asked.

“I am just Kenyan,” I said, feeling unsure.

The incessant laughter that followed from the fifth-grade students, together with the teacher’s struggle to maintain her composure, was the first time I realized the magnitude of the missing piece of the jigsaw puzzle - the central feature of my personality that I had technically ignored for the greater part of my early childhood. All along I had programmed myself to think that I was Kenyan and abandoned the cultures that my forefathers had preserved for generations with the hope that one day they would be passed down to a child like me.

To answer my questions, I went to visit my grandmother. She spoke to me fluently in Kikuyu. I couldn’t shake off my shame as I replied that I didn’t understand her in English. She then revealed that I was from the Kikuyu tribe, a fact that had been kept secret my entire life.

To welcome my culture, our holiday language classes immediately began. She loved hearing me speak Kikuyu because she enjoyed laughing at me mispronouncing words and making completely incoherent statements. Sometimes I couldn’t help but join in her laughter. Eventually, I embraced my flawed speech and felt like I could just be myself. She would then constantly refer to me as ‘Macharia’, a Kikuyu name meaning, the one who looks for. In my quest to learn more about my culture, I delved deeper by reading poems and manuscripts such as the Bible in Kikuyu.

As I further explored the Kikuyu culture, I became increasingly enamored with its customs and practices. It was a Pandora’s box of treasures, each one more precious and meaningful than the last. I was particularly entranced by the intricate beauty of traditional music and dance and eagerly absorbed the melodies and choreography. She taught me a traditional Kikuyu song called ‘Uriigu’, a song the youth danced to. As she sang, I tried to follow along and mimic the dance moves. Despite my missteps, my grandmother beamed with pride and joy. Yes, this was the magic of culture: it weaved a spell of unity among its performers.

Kikuyu culture has given me a sense of grounding, its roots are sunken deeply in my heart. Despite my initial shame in not knowing my tribe, discovering my culture was ultimately liberating. Our language, which was the fabric that knitted our community together, was also interwoven with other languages, making one cloth, helping to foster harmonious relations in our ethnically divided country. I know why grandma spoke to me in Kikuyu, it is because there is a connection between the new and old generations that brings meaning to life.

Though I cried when my grandmother literally found her way home to our ancestors, I will always be grateful for the invaluable lessons she imparted to me. Through her guidance, I was able to cultivate a profound appreciation for the rich tapestry of my heritage, adding new meaning to my identity. I now

embody the quality of relentless pursuit, which is linked to my unofficial Kikuyu name. It is one of my many core values; it drives me to be excellent, motivates me to be successful, and channels into my passion for impacting others for a more peaceful community.